

Module 2: Migration Data and Global Trends

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

Students work like analysts: using real datasets, they produce a short professional data brief that identifies genuine migration trends and — just as important — names who is missing from the numbers. The brief format teaches evidence communication for policy audiences.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Interpret migration datasets from at least two sources (UG 1)
- Identify trends supported by the data, not headlines (UG 2)
- Recognize missing populations — children, undocumented people, people with disabilities (UG 3)
- Explain data limitations in plain language (UG 4)

Graduate extension

Graduate students critique the reliability and bias of their chosen datasets and close the brief with a concrete, feasible proposal for improving data collection on one invisible population (Grad 1–2).

Assignment steps

1. Choose a region, corridor, or population (e.g., Venezuelan displacement, Mediterranean crossings, South–South labor migration in Asia).
2. Pull data from at least two of: UN DESA international migrant stock, UNHCR Refugee Data Finder, IOM World Migration Report / Missing Migrants, World Bank remittances.
3. Identify 2–3 defensible trends; build one chart or table per trend with sources and years labeled.
4. Write the 'blind spots' section: who is not counted here, why, and how that gap could distort policy conclusions.
5. Draft the brief in professional format: headline findings up top, evidence in the middle, limitations clearly stated — no burying caveats.
6. Peer-exchange drafts in class; check each other's charts against the underlying numbers before final submission.

Deliverables & format

- Data brief, 3–4 pages including 2–3 original charts or tables (graduate adds a 1-page data-improvement proposal)
- All data sources cited with dataset name, publisher, and year
- One-paragraph executive summary written for a non-specialist reader

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Accuracy of data handling and sourcing 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: accuracy of data handling and sourcing is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: accuracy of data handling and sourcing is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: accuracy of data handling and sourcing is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: accuracy of data handling and sourcing is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Validity of identified trends — claims match the evidence 25%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: validity of identified trends — claims match the evidence is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: validity of identified trends — claims match the evidence is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: validity of identified trends — claims match the evidence is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: validity of identified trends — claims match the evidence is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Quality of the blind-spots analysis 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: quality of the blind-spots analysis goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: quality of the blind-spots analysis is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: quality of the blind-spots analysis is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: quality of the blind-spots analysis is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Professional communication: clarity, charts, executive summary 20%	Communication is publication-ready: professional communication: clarity, charts, executive summary is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: professional communication: clarity, charts, executive summary is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: professional communication: clarity, charts, executive summary is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: professional communication: clarity, charts, executive summary is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.